Ingredient Substitutions

You're out of something — here's what to reach for instead

DAIRY & FATS

YOU NEED…	USE INSTEAD (1 : 1 UNLESS NOTED)
Butter, baking	Equal coconut oil, or ¾ cup oil per 1 cup butter
Buttermilk	1 cup milk + 1 Tbsp lemon juice or vinegar; rest 5 min
Sour cream / yogurt	Swap for each other, or pureed cottage cheese
Heavy cream, for sauce	¾ cup milk + ¼ cup melted butter
Milk, in baking	Equal water + 1 tsp butter per cup; or watered yogurt

EGGS (PER EGG, IN BAKING)

SUBSTITUTE	AMOUNT	WORKS BEST FOR
Flax egg	1 Tbsp ground flax + 3 Tbsp water, rest 5 min	Muffins, quick breads
Applesauce	¼ cup unsweetened	Moist cakes and brownies
Mashed banana	¼ cup	Pancakes, sweet breads
Yogurt	¼ cup	Cakes
Commercial egg replacer	Per package directions	Anything

PANTRY BAKING

YOU NEED…	USE INSTEAD
1 tsp baking powder	¼ tsp baking soda + ½ tsp cream of tartar (or ⅓ tsp soda + acidic liquid in recipe)
1 tsp baking soda	2–3 tsp baking powder (omit recipe salt)
1 cup cake flour	1 cup AP flour − 2 Tbsp, + 2 Tbsp cornstarch
1 cup self-rising flour	1 cup AP flour + 1½ tsp baking powder + ¼ tsp salt
Honey / sugar swap	Honey is sweeter: use ¾ cup honey for 1 cup sugar, cut liquid 2 Tbsp, lower oven 25 °F
Cornstarch	2 Tbsp flour per 1 Tbsp cornstarch (cook longer)

HERBS, SPICES & FLAVOR

YOU NEED…	USE INSTEAD
Fresh herb (1 Tbsp)	1 tsp dried, added earlier in cooking
Dried herb (1 tsp)	1 Tbsp fresh, added at the end
Lemon juice	Vinegar or lime juice, equal amount
Garlic clove	½ tsp jarred minced or ⅛ tsp powder
Fresh ginger	¼ tsp ground per 1 Tbsp fresh
Worcestershire	Soy sauce + splash of vinegar + pinch sugar
Dijon mustard	1 tsp yellow mustard + pinch cayenne

GRAINS, PASTA & MEAT

YOU NEED…	USE INSTEAD
Quinoa	Any grain cooked 1 : 2 with water (couscous, rice, millet)
Panko or breadcrumbs (1 cup)	Crushed crackers, or ¾ cup oats + ¼ cup flour
Ground beef	Equal ground turkey (add 1 tsp oil), or lentils up to half
Chicken stock	Bouillon: 1 cube or 1 tsp granules per 1 cup hot water

> **Golden rule:** match the function — moisture, fat, lift, acid, or binding — not the exact name. A sour cream swap that tastes different but bakes the same is a win.